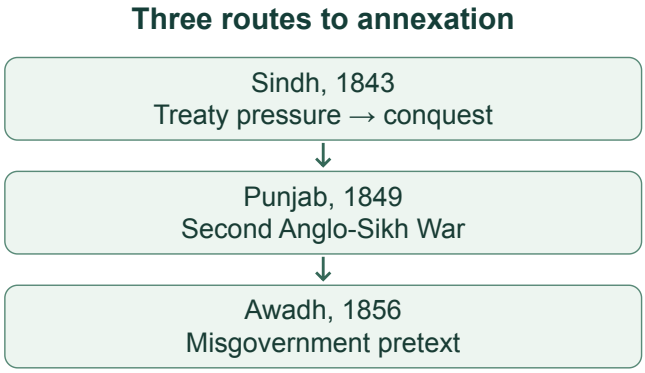
British Expansion in North India (Conquest of Sindh, Punjab and Awadh, 1843-57)

Three routes to annexation

Region	Annexation	Key official	Method / justification
Sindh	**1843**	Ellenborough; Charles Napier	Treaty pressure followed by military conquest
Punjab	**29 March 1849**	Dalhousie; Hugh Gough	Second Anglo-Sikh War
Awadh	**1856**	Dalhousie; Outram	Alleged misgovernment; **not Doctrine of Lapse**



Three routes to annexation

British commercial ambitions, revenue needs and northwest security reinforced each other. Claims of restoring prestige after the Afghan disaster were part of the context, not a complete explanation for every annexation.

Sindh: from friendship to conquest

Talpuras: Baluch ruling house established power in the **1780s** under **Mir Fateh Ali Khan**; subsequent Amirs shared authority (the 'Char Yar' arrangement). Their territories included Hyderabad and strategically important Indus centres.

Treaty sequence

Date	Step	Significance
1807-09 context	Minto sent Malcolm to Persia, Elphinstone to Kabul, Metcalfe to Lahore and Seton to Sindh	Counter Napoleonic/French influence
1809	Friendship treaty with the Amirs	Exclusion of French settlement

Date	Step	Significance
1820	Renewed arrangements	Restrictions extended to other European/American outsiders; the source's 'exclude the Americans from Sindh' concerns foreign settlement, not expulsion of an American government
1832	Commercial treaty negotiated through Henry Pottinger under Bentinck	British merchants/navigation admitted to Indus commerce
1839	Subsidiary arrangements and British representative at Hyderabad	Afghan expedition increased military and financial pressure
1842	Ellenborough succeeded Auckland; Napier sent to Sindh, replacing Outram's leading role	Escalation toward annexation
1843	Battles of **Miani and Dabo**	Napier defeated the Amirs; Sindh annexed
1847	Sindh incorporated into Bombay Presidency	Administrative integration

Why Sindh mattered: Indus trade/navigation, access toward Afghanistan, frontier fears and the desire to repair British prestige. British troops occupied **Shikarpur, Bukkur and Karachi** during the Afghan campaign and extracted payments despite earlier treaty assurances. Sikh pressure toward Sindh was used as a pretext for unsolicited 'protection'.

Evaluation: coercive treaty revision and disproportionate conquest make the episode an example of expansion under the language of security. Napier's notorious defence of annexation acknowledged its questionable legitimacy; avoid presenting that defence as a neutral historical judgment.

Punjab after Ranjit Singh

June 1839: Ranjit Singh died. Succession struggles followed: Kharak Singh, Nau Nihal Singh and others; **1843:** minor **Duleep/Dalip Singh** installed, with **Rani Jindan** as regent. Rapid growth of the Khalsa army, fiscal pressure and court factionalism weakened stable authority.

British troop concentrations, the annexation of Sindh and political-agent **Broadfoot's** conduct intensified suspicion. **Hardinge** became Governor-General in **1844**. **Lal Singh** was wazir, **Tej Singh** a leading commander; the Company's commander-in-chief was **Hugh Gough**.

Causes of war: British territorial/security ambition, Punjab's wealth, succession instability, army-court tensions, mutual mistrust and frontier military preparations. Accusations that Sikh leaders deliberately diverted an uncontrollable army into war are interpretations; do not present personal allegations about Rani Jindan as established causes.

First Anglo-Sikh War (1845-46)

Sikh forces crossed the Sutlej in **December 1845**; Hardinge declared war on **13 December**. British preparations and Sikh action must both be included.

Battle	Date / result
Mudki	18 December 1845

Battle	Date / result
Ferozeshah	21-22 December 1845; costly British success
Baddowal	January 1846; Sikh success against British movement
Aliwal	28 January 1846; Harry Smith's British victory
Sobraon	**10 February 1846**; decisive British victory

Sikh soldiers resisted fiercely. Alleged betrayal by Lal Singh/Tej Singh figures in accounts, but superior resources, command decisions and battlefield conditions also matter. National Army Museum: First Sikh War.

Treaties: Lahore is not Amritsar

Treaty	Main terms
Lahore, 9 March 1846	Loss of territories/claims south of Sutlej and Jalandhar Doab; ₹1.5-crore indemnity, territorial cessions in lieu of part; reduction of army; Duleep recognised; Henry Lawrence became Resident
Amritsar, 16 March 1846	Specified hill territories including Kashmir transferred to **Gulab Singh for ₹75 lakh Nanakshahi**, not ₹1 crore as the source states
Bhairowal, 16 December 1846	Regency council of eight Sikh chiefs under British Resident; British troops maintained at Lahore; effective British control during the minority; Jindan excluded from governing authority

The source prints Bhairowal as **22 December**; distinguish the treaty date **16 December** from subsequent arrangements. Lahore and Amritsar had different parties and functions. Treaty of Amritsar, Articles I and III; Sikh Museum Initiative: treaty records.

Why no immediate annexation? The Khalsa was weakened but not eliminated; resistance, administrative cost and military resources favoured indirect control first. 'Respect for Ranjit Singh' alone is inadequate.



Punjab: indirect to direct control

Second Anglo-Sikh War (1848-49)

Trigger and campaign

British intervention under the regency, Jindan's removal and growing resentment formed the background. **April 1848:** British officers **Vans Agnew and Anderson** were killed at Multan during the replacement of governor **Mulraj**. Revolt spread; **Sher Singh Attariwala** became a major rebel leader. Dalhousie used the crisis to pursue annexation.

Battle	Date	Recall
Ramnagar	**22 November 1848**	Inconclusive/costly encounter
Chillianwala	**13 January 1849**	Heavy British losses; no decisive settlement
Gujrat	**21 February 1849**	Decisive victory under **Hugh Gough**

Correction: Charles Napier conquered Sindh; **Gough**, not Napier, commanded at Gujrat. Napier was appointed to replace Gough after criticism, but the decisive battle occurred before he assumed command. National Army Museum: Second Sikh War.

29 March 1849: Punjab annexed; Duleep pensioned, later taken to Britain; Koh-i-Noor surrendered under the annexation settlement. A Board of Administration led by **Henry Lawrence**, with **John Lawrence** and **Charles Mansel**, administered Punjab.

Evaluation: extended frontier access and British strategic control; critics saw a breach of the Company's guardianship obligations toward a minor ruler. British effective control under Bhairowal complicates blaming the child Maharaja for rebellion.

Dalhousie (1848-56): annexations and reforms

Doctrine of Lapse: precise definition

For specified dependent states, British authorities refused to recognise an adopted heir's right to **political succession** when the ruler died without a recognised natural male heir; state territory could be annexed. **Private inheritance/adoption was not simply outlawed. Misgovernment was a separate justification.**

Dalhousie systematised earlier practice, not invented it from nothing: Directors' policy from **1834**, Mandvi **1839**, Jalaun and other small states **1840** preceded him. Names and classifications of minor states vary; do not confuse **Jaitpur with Jaipur** or **Udaipur in central India with Mewar**.

Main examples	Date / distinction
Satara	**1848**, lapse
Jaitpur and Sambalpur	**1849**, lapse
Baghat	**1850**, minor-state case; later reversed
Udaipur (central India)	**1852**, not Rajasthan's Mewar

Main examples	Date / distinction
Jhansi	Ruler died **1853**; annexation **1854**
Nagpur	Ruler died **1853**; annexation **1854**
Carnatic / Tanjore	Titles/pensions or residual sovereignty dealt with in **1855**; not interchangeable with every territorial lapse
Berar	**1853**, assigned by Hyderabad for contingent expenses; not a lapse annexation
Awadh	**1856**, alleged misgovernment

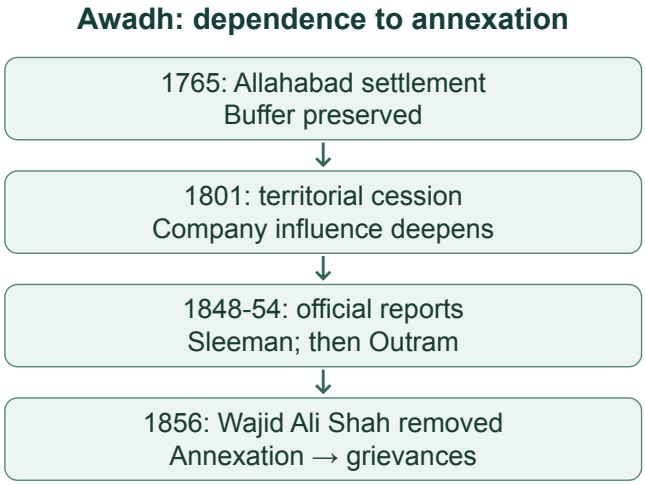
Refusal of pensions/titles, including Nana Sahib's pension claim after Baji Rao II, deepened elite grievances.

Reforms and their purpose

- Administrative centralisation; commissioners for newly acquired territories; military centres shifted toward northern/western frontiers.
- **Wood's Despatch, July 1854:** educational structure, provincial departments, grants, training and universities; Bombay, Madras and Calcutta universities followed in **1857**.
- **1853:** Bombay-Thane passenger railway and Railway Minute; **1854:** separate Public Works Department, postal reforms and expanding telegraph network.
- Railways, canals, roads, post and telegraph served revenue, commerce and troop movement, while also creating infrastructure later used by Indians. **W.B. O'Shaughnessy**, rather than Dalhousie alone, is associated with developing the electric telegraph.

Balanced evaluation: durable infrastructure and administrative changes coexisted with aggressive imperial expansion and social/fiscal disruption; annexations helped create grievances feeding the **1857 revolt**.

Awadh: dependence to annexation



Awadh: dependence to annexation

Date	Development
1764-65	Buxar followed by Allahabad settlement; Clive retained Awadh as a buffer rather than annexing it
1774	Shuja-ud-Daula expanded into Rohilkhand with Company military support
1775	Asaf-ud-Daula succeeded; Company influence grew
1801	Wellesley forced Saadat Ali Khan to cede about half his territory, including lower Doab, Gorakhpur and Rohilkhand; subsidy replaced by territorial support and obligations of administrative reform
1848	Dalhousie appointed Sleeman Resident at Lucknow; reports criticised governance but did not advocate outright annexation
1854	Outram succeeded Sleeman and supplied further reports
1856	Wajid Ali Shah deposed; Awadh annexed on alleged misgovernment; king moved to Calcutta
1857	Widespread Awadh resistance; Begum Hazrat Mahal prominent in the later revolt

The **1765 Allahabad settlement is not the same as Wellesley's 1801 subsidiary arrangement**. British protection and interference made the Company partly responsible for the condition it later used to justify annexation.

Effects: dismantled court and army → loss of employment/patronage for soldiers, artisans and retainers; summary revenue settlement dispossessed many taluqdars; peasants faced heavier burdens; sepoys with Awadh family/land connections felt directly affected. This explains broad rural mobilisation in 1857 without relying on the source's unsupported precise 'three-fourths of adults' estimate.

North-Western Provinces: avoid a geography trap

- **Ceded and Conquered Provinces:** Company acquisitions of **1801-06**, broadly in present Uttar Pradesh.
- **1836:** North-Western Provinces organised; distinct from the later **North-West Frontier Province**.
- **1856:** Awadh annexed but initially administered separately. Administrative association with the North-Western Provinces developed later, notably **1877**; do not call it a single merged province from 1856.
- **1858:** Allahabad became an important provincial seat and the venue of the royal proclamation; avoid the loosely repeated 'capital of India for one day' claim.
- **1902:** United Provinces of Agra and Oudh; territorial changes after 1857 included Delhi's transfer toward Punjab administration.

PYQs and mains recall

2004 matching: 1790-92 = Third Anglo-Mysore; 1824-26 = First Anglo-Burmese; therefore pairs **2 and 3**, option **d**. **2007:** ruler removed for misgovernment = **Awadh**, option **a**.

Mains structure: strategic/commercial motives → unequal treaties/war or administrative pretexts → annexation → social and revenue consequences → connection to 1857. Distinguish **Sindh-Napier**, **Punjab-Gough**, **Awadh-misgovernment**, **Jhansi-lapse**.